

THE CONSONANTS AT LAW

SIGMA *vs.* TAU, IN THE COURT OF THE SEVEN VOWELS

This mock prosecution, probably not by Lucian, but much later than his time, is based upon the fact that in the Attic dialect many words originally written with double *s* came eventually to be pronounced and written with double *t*, and incidentally mentions words in which *l* has been substituted for *r*; *g* for *k* and *l*; *z*, *x* and *r* for *s*, and *t* for *d*, *th*, and *z*. It cannot be adequately translated, for we have nothing of that sort in English.

ΔΙΚΗ ΣΥΜΦΩΝΩΝ ΤΟΥ ΣΙΓΜΑ ΠΡΟΣ
ΤΟ ΤΑΥ ΥΠΟ ΤΟΙΣ ΕΠΤΑ ΦΩΝΗΕΣΙΝ¹

[Ἐπὶ ἀρχοντος Ἀριστάρχου Φαληρέως, Πυανεψιδῶνος¹
ἐβδόμη ἰσταμένου, γραφὴν ἔθετο τὸ Σίγμα πρὸς τὸ Ταῦ
ἐπὶ τῶν ἐπτά Φωνηέντων βίας καὶ ὑπαρχόντων ἀρπαγῆς,
ἀφηρῆσθαι λέγον πάντων τῶν ἐν διπλῷ ταῦ ἐκφε-
ρομένων.]²

Μέχρι μὲν, ὦ Φωνήεντα δικασταί, ὀλίγα ἡδικοῦμην ὑπὸ²
τουτοῦ τοῦ Ταῦ καταχρωμένου τοῖς ἔμοις καὶ καταίροντος
ἐνθα μὴ δεῖ, οὐ βαρέως ἔφερον τὴν βλάβην καὶ παρήκουον
ἐνια τῶν λεγομένων ὑπὸ τῆς μετριότητος, ἦν ἴστε με
φυλάσσοντα πρὸς τε ὑμᾶς καὶ τὰς ἄλλας συλλαβάς· ἐπεὶ δὲ
ἐς τοσοῦτον ἦκει πλεονεξίας τε καὶ ἀνομίας,³ ὥστε ἐφ' οἷς
ἡσύχασα πολλάκις οὐκ ἀγαπῶν, ἀλλ'⁴ ἤδη καὶ πλείω προ-
σβάλλεται, ἀναγκαιῶς αὐτὸ εὐθύνα νῦν παρὰ τοῖς ἀμφοτέροις
εἰδόσιν ὑμῖν. δέος δὲ οὐ μικρὸν μοι ἐπὶ τούτοις⁵ τῆς ἀπο-
θλίψεως ἐπέρχεται τῆς ἐμαυτοῦ· τοῖς γὰρ προπεπραγμένοις
αἰεὶ τι μεῖζον προστιθὲν ἄρδην με τῆς οἰκείας ἀποθλίψει
χώρας, ὥς ὀλίγου δεῖν ἡσυχίαν ἀγαγόντα μηδὲ ἐν γράμμασιν
ἀριθμεῖσθαι, ἐν ἴσῳ δὲ κεῖσθαι τοῦ φόβου.⁶

¹ So in Γ: ΔΙΚΗ ΦΩΝΗΕΝΤΩΝ vulg. ² Wanting in Γ.

³ ἀνομίας Lehmann, Herwerden, Sommerbrodt: ἀνοίας MSS. ⁴ ἀλλ' K. Schwartz: ἀλλ' (or word omitted) MSS.

⁵ τούτοις Herwerden: τοῖς (τῆς) MSS. ⁶ φόβου Γ: φόβου ΩΣ.

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[In the year that Aristarchus of Phalerum was archon,
on the seventh day of the month Pyanepsion, Sigma
brought suit against Tau before the seven Vowels for
assault and robbery, alleging that he had stolen all the
words that are pronounced with double tau.]

Vowels of the jury, as long as the wrongs that I underwent
at the hands of this fellow Tau through his misusing my
property and establishing himself where he had no business
were but slight, I did not take the injury to heart, and I ignored
some of the things that I heard because of the equable temper
which, as you know, I maintain toward you and the other
letters. But now that he has come to such a pitch of self
seeking and lawlessness that, not content with what I have
repeatedly let pass in silence, he is trying to wrest still more
from me, I am compelled to call him to account before you,
who know both sides. Besides all this, I am more than a little
afraid of my own ejection; for by making greater and greater
additions to what he has already done he will altogether eject
me from my own estate, so that if I keep quiet I shall scarcely
count at all as a letter and shall be no better than a hiss.